

Commonplace

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Orientation

Meaning is not a property of objects. Certain objects are meaningful to certain people, but not to others. Subjects can not generate meaning. None of us can generate meaning at will. None of us can experience meaning at will. Meaning, emerges during the right interaction between the subject and the object.

Since meaning is not a property *of* objects, there is no meaning *of* life. Since meaning emerges out of your interactions with life, there is meaning *in* your interactions with life, there is meaning *in* life.

The question "What is the meaning of life?" would have required a propositional answer, such as "The meaning of life is X." But we have seen that this is not the right question, since there is no meaning of life. Because meaning is found during interactions, the right question is "How can I interact with life such that I can experience meaning?" This question does not expect a proposition as an answer, but an interaction. Thus, we get,

The first change in orientation: from rigid ideas and abstract ideals to the lived experience.

There is no distant objective meaning of life X that you have to strive towards, but rather, each and every one of your interactions with life can either be a meaningful one or not.

There is no way to Nirvana, Nirvana is the way.

— Thich Nhat Hanh, "The Heart of the Buddha's Teaching"

There is no Nirvana outside of your practice.

— Shunryu Suzuki, "Zen Mind, Beginner's Mind"

Neither shall they say, Lo here! or, lo there! for, behold, the kingdom of God is within you.

— Luke 17:21, KJV

As such, with regards to meaning,

Virtue is the only good, and vice the only evil; everything else is indifferent.

— Seneca, "Letters to Lucilius", Letter LXXVI

Thus, paradoxically, pursuing the distant and abstract ideal of "having (what I rigidly imagine to be instead of what actually is) a meaningful life" prevents you from actually living a meaningful life. As practitioners, we don't want to live a meaningful life, we just engage in meaningful actions. From this we get,

The second change in orientation: from having (a meaningful life, a virtuous character, objects, achievements, status, desired circumstances) to engaging in the right interactions.

From attachment springs grief, from attachment springs fear. For one who is wholly free from attachment there is no grief, whence then fear?
— Dhammapada, verse 214

It is not the man who has too little, but the man who craves more, who is poor.
— Seneca, "Letters to Lucilius", Letter II

It is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle than for someone who is rich to enter the kingdom of God.
— Matthew 19:24, NRSVUE

Now, because meaning emerges during interaction, living a meaningful life also involves

The third change in orientation: from self-centeredness to caring for others.

At the core of a meaningful life is the shift from "How can the world be relevant to me? How can I derive what I want from it? How can I make it fit my ideas?" to "How can I be relevant to the world? How can I be relevant to myself, to others, and to something that transcends me (e.g., a child, a form of art)?" This is a synthesis of John Vervaeke's research on meaning in life and it aligns with findings from the 80-year Harvard Study of Adult Development. As the study authors conclude:

Among Harvard Study participants, the happiest and the most satisfied adults were those who managed to turn the question "What can I do for myself?" into "What can I do for the world beyond me?"
— Robert Waldinger and Mark Schulz, "The Good Life"

All the suffering in the world comes from the desire for oneself to be happy. All the happiness in the world comes from the desire for others to be happy.
— (Dalai Lama's paraphrase of) Shantideva, "Bodhicaryāvatāra" (A Guide to the Bodhisattva's Way of Life), 8:129

No one can lead a happy life if he thinks only of himself and turns everything to his own purposes. You should live for the other person if you wish to live for yourself.
— Seneca, "Letters to Lucilius", Letter XLVIII

Whoever wishes to be great among you must be your servant, and whoever wishes to be first among you must be your slave, just as the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve and to give his life a ransom for many.
— Matthew 20:26–28, NRSVUE

Perspective

Consider how the chain of causation works using this example of a person holding a glass of water in the air:

The First Link: The glass of water has the potential to be up in the air but it actually is in the

air only because my hand actually holds it there right now. My hand has the potential to hold the glass in the air but having the potential is not enough; my hand has to *actually* hold the glass in the air.

The Second Link: My hand has the potential to hold the glass in the air, but in order to actually do so it needs my arm to actually support it right now in this position.

The Third Link: My arm has the potential to hold my hand in that position, but in order to do so it needs my shoulder to actually hold it so that it can actually hold the hand so that the glass can actually be in the air.

The General Rule: Each link borrows its actualizing power from the link above it. If at any second you were to take away any link from this chain, everything further down the chain would lose its causal power. If you take away the shoulder, the glass will fall on the ground; it will no longer be up in the air, and neither will the arm or the hand. Everything that has a potential requires a prior link to actualize that potential.

The Final Link: Because no link from the chain actually has any actualizing power, because every link just borrows it from the link above, the chain can not go indefinitely, since then there will be no actualizing power in the chain. The chain must terminate in a source of actualizing power. And that source has to have no unactualized potential, so that it does not require a prior cause. Thus, the ultimate cause of everything, the Nature of all things, the Causeless Cause, the Self-Moving Mover as Plato would call it, that lends its actualizing power to the links down the causal chain, God, is pure actuality with no unactualized potential, namely: Existence itself.

And God said unto Moses, I AM THAT I AM: and he said, Thus shalt thou say unto the children of Israel, I AM hath sent me unto you.

— Exodus 3:14, KJV

God actively creates us and actively grounds our very being in each and every moment we exist. Remember, if at any moment any part of the chain ceases to actively actualize the next, the whole chain from that point forward drops. God doesn't just passively exist, God currently and actively actualizes our very being. It is present within our very being during each and every moment just like the laws of physics are present within the trajectory of every falling rock at every given moment, actively creating, actively shaping that trajectory; you cannot see them, you cannot touch them, but you cannot deny their existence and their active effect. We are icons of God because God is present within us in each and every moment. God is present within each and every thing in each and every moment.

Where can I go from your spirit? Or where can I flee from your presence? If I ascend to heaven, you are there; if I make my bed in Sheol, you are there. If I take the wings of the morning and settle at the farthest limits of the sea, even there your hand shall lead me, and your right hand shall hold me fast.

— Psalms 139:7–10, NRSVUE

Since we are icons of God, since you can see God in each and every human being, when

the righteous will answer him, "Lord, when did we see you hungry and feed you, or thirsty and give you something to drink? When did we see you a stranger and invite you in, or needing clothes and clothe you? When did we see you sick or

in prison and go to visit you?"
The King will reply, "Truly I tell you, whatever you did for one of the least of these brothers and sisters of mine, you did for me."

— Matthew 25:37–40, NIV

Thus, the meaningful life can be summarized in a single sentence:

Love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your strength and with all your mind and your neighbor as yourself.

— Luke 10:27, NRSVUE

Since both you and your neighbor are children of God and icons of God;

or do you not know that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit within you, which you have from God, and that you are not your own? For you were bought with a price; therefore glorify God in your body.

— 1 Corinthians 6:19, NRSVUE

However, it is important to remember that, while God is present within you and within your neighbor, neither you nor your neighbor are God. A priest once told me that "God sees me through you and sees you through me but neither of us are God". God is fully immanent and fully transcendent at the same time. While God is present within every thing, God is not any particular thing.

That which grounds and explains all things is not itself any particular thing; just like the laws of nature that cause and explain the trajectory of every falling rock are not themselves a trajectory of a falling rock. That which grounds and explains all beings is not a(ny) being. Aside from God

not being any thing, to take things even further, nothing affirmative can ever be said about God. That which grounds and explains both the finite and the infinite is neither finite nor infinite; it is the source of both the finite and the infinite. That which grounds and explains both the good and the bad is neither good nor bad; it lives beyond them. Every idea we have about God is wrong. Even imagining God as a cause is wrong; the cause of all causes is not itself a cause.

You cannot see my face, for no one shall see me and live.

— Exodus 33:20, NRSVUE

Nothing that exists can perceive God; that which grounds and explains all things that exists is not a thing that exists and that we can perceive, God is beyond existence. Capital "E" Existence itself is not existence (as in the things that exist); it is that which grounds and explains all of existence. Thus, every idea that exists in your mind about God is wrong, and if you serve it you are only serving your own intellect; you miss out the real God and you end up in spiritual death. Therefore,

you shall not make for yourself an idol, whether in the form of anything that is in heaven above or that is on the earth beneath or that is in the water under the earth. You shall not bow down to them or serve them.

— Exodus 20:4–5, NRSVUE

Practice

Now as they went on their way, he entered a certain village where a woman named Martha welcomed him. She had a sister named Mary, who sat at Jesus's feet and

listened to what he was saying. But Martha was distracted by her many tasks, so she came to him and asked, "Lord, do you not care that my sister has left me to do all the work by myself? Tell her, then, to help me." But the Lord answered her, "Martha, Martha, you are worried and distracted by many things, but few things are needed—indeed only one. Mary has chosen the better part, which will not be taken away from her."

— Luke 10:38–42, NRSVUE

Placing yourself at God's feet in a state of adoration is the only thing that is required for a meaningful life. Once you develop your love for God, and you start to see God in yourself and others, the natural result is the manifestation of that love in the form of serving the other. Notice how this service is not a means to an end but rather it is an end itself. The manifestation of your love of God in the form of serving your neighbor is the meaningful life being fully lived right now. It is the enacted answer to the question "What can I do for the world beyond me?" from the 80-year Harvard Study of Adult Development and from Dr. John Vervaeke's research on meaning in life.